

501(c)(3) Filing Checklist

For Knights of The Kingdom of Christ Order

501(c)(3) Filing Checklist

Step 1 — Formation • Choose a legal nonprofit name that does not falsely imply government, military, church, or historical authority you do not actually have. • Form a nonprofit corporation in your state. • Appoint a registered agent. • File the state nonprofit formation document. • Hold the organizational meeting. • Adopt your Articles of Incorporation and bylaws. • Elect your initial board and officers. • Open a corporate records book.

Step 2 — 501(c)(3)-Ready Governing Documents • Make sure the Articles contain a proper exempt-purpose clause suitable for 501(c)(3). • Make sure the Articles contain a dissolution clause sending assets to another exempt purpose or government public purpose if the corporation dissolves. • Make sure your documents describe the organization as charitable, religious, and/or educational — not as a militia, private security force, or private armed body. • If bylaws have been adopted, keep a current signed copy ready for the IRS file.

Step 3 — Mission Fit • Write a short mission statement focused on public benefit. • List your first-year and second-year programs, such as scholarships, charitable aid, educational talks, historical research, publications, clergy support, youth mentoring, food relief, or heritage preservation. • Avoid describing the order as mainly a private fellowship club for members only. • Avoid any language suggesting law-enforcement, patrol, armed readiness, or military training.

Step 4 — EIN and Tax Accounts • Get a separate Employer Identification Number for the corporation. • Do this before submitting the exemption application. • Use the EIN on all IRS forms, bank accounts, and governing records.

Step 5 — Choose the IRS Application • Determine whether you are eligible for Form 1023-EZ or need the full Form 1023. • File electronically through Pay.gov. • If there is doubt about complexity, related entities, unusual activities, or governance issues, use the full Form 1023.

Step 6 — Full Form 1023 Document Set If filing full Form 1023, assemble: filed Articles of Incorporation or other state-approved organizing document; certification that the organizing document copy is complete and accurate; current bylaws, if adopted; a full narrative of past, present, and planned activities; description of fundraising methods; names of officers, directors, and key persons; compensation arrangements, if any; conflict-of-interest policy, if adopted; financial statements; current balance sheet or current statement of assets and liabilities; revenue and expense statements for completed periods, if operating already; proposed budgets for two full accounting periods if the organization is new or under one year old; and the user fee payment through Pay.gov.

Step 7 — Narrative Description Checklist • Describe each activity in plain English. • State who benefits: the public, students, clergy, the poor, historical audiences, and so on. • State how often the activity happens. • State whether any activity is members-only or public-facing. • Describe publications, lectures, retreats, ceremonies, or charitable distributions. • Describe how funds are raised and spent. • Explain how Templar-inspired ranks are internal and ceremonial, not governmental or military. • Explain why the organization's activities are charitable, religious, or educational rather than private social recreation.

Step 8 — Finance Checklist • Create a startup budget for Year 1 and Year 2. • Separate expected revenue sources: dues, donations, grants, event income, merchandise, sponsorships. • Separate expected expenses: charitable programs, educational events, administration, insurance, printing, web hosting, regalia, rent, and professional fees. • Keep program expenses clearly connected to exempt purposes. • Open a dedicated bank account in the corporate name. • Require documented approval for reimbursements. • Avoid personal use of organization funds.

Step 9 — Governance Checklist • Keep at least the minimum number of directors required by your state. • Record board meeting minutes. • Adopt a conflict-of-interest policy. • Adopt a code of conduct. • Adopt a document-retention policy. • Approve officer roles in writing. • Make clear that ceremonial offices like Grand Master, Seneschal, and Marshal are internal nonprofit offices only.

Step 10 — Fundraising and Solicitation • Before asking the public for donations, check whether your state requires charitable solicitation registration. • If you solicit online, review whether other states may also require registration. • Check whether your state or locality requires annual charity reports. • If you use paid fundraisers or fundraising counsel, review those additional rules too. • Use the National Association of State Charity Officials to find the right state regulator.

Step 11 — Compliance Risks Specific to the Order • Do not hold the organization out as a militia, patrol, enforcement, or armed service. • Do not imply Vatican, royal, or sovereign recognition unless you actually have it. • Do not claim to be the original medieval Knights Templar. • Do not use uniforms or ranks in a way that implies police or military authority. • Do not let insiders receive improper private benefit. • Do not let charitable funds be diverted to personal expenses.

Step 12 — Filing Submission • Create a Pay.gov account. • Complete Form 1023 or 1023-EZ online. • Upload all required attachments. • Double-check names, EIN, addresses, dates, and officer list. • Pay the user fee. • Save PDFs of everything submitted. • Track the application status afterward through the IRS process pages.

Step 13 — After Approval • Save the IRS determination letter permanently. • Update donation language and website materials to reflect recognized status. • File annual IRS returns: Form 990, 990-EZ, or 990-N, depending on size and eligibility. • File Form 990-T if there is sufficient unrelated business income. • File payroll tax forms if you hire employees. • Keep state annual reports and charitable registrations current. • Do not miss three straight annual IRS filings, or exempt status can be automatically revoked.

Step 14 — BOI / CTA As of the current FinCEN rule summarized in this conversation, entities created in the United States are exempt from BOI reporting. Continue monitoring FinCEN for changes.